

was the population of Botswana in 1950? What countries are the largest, surface-area wise? How much rice was produced in Sierra Leone in 1995? We can bet our last rupee you won't need that last figure, of course, but what we're trying to say is that figures do say something, and that therefore, you can get a sort of bird's-eye view of the stuff the world is made of.

This section can also be seen as a wealth of trivia: you look at the projected population figures for 2050, and you see the following: India at the top with 1.5 billion, China next, the US third, and Pakistan fourth. And, for example, where are the wealthiest people? You have a link called "Gross National Income (total and per capita) for most countries for 2000 and 2003."

The second way of getting into this site is via the Country Data link. You have every country listed, in alphabetical order. You'll get the vital stats for each country—area, population, capital, regions, and such.

Now click "Mali" and you'll find "Tombouctou," and that its population is about a lakh. That's really Timbuktu in disguise. It just so happened we knew where the place was (in Mali), that's why we got to it. And that's the big, big problem with the site: there's no search box anywhere. At least we couldn't find one.

Under the Charts section, you'll find not too many—but those that are there are interesting. "Largest countries 1950–2050," "Age structure graph", and some more along those lines.

So this one is for

- Trivia: explore the site and find interesting figures.
- Extrapolations to 2050 in several cases, which can be interesting.
- Perspectives: India is 55 Australias in terms of people.
- Authority: Most figures are from *The World Factbook 2005-2006*, CIA. The CIA as in Central Intelligence Agency. So you can quote from this page.